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# IsHaunted.com

The complete product documentation — every screen, rule and safeguard, written for the people who use it.

PRODUCT DOCUMENTATION

9 DOCUMENTS · 6 SECTIONS

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## About this document

This is the in-product help, reproduced in full and unaltered — the same text the application serves to its users. It describes the software as built. It contains no business, market or financial information, and no usage figures.

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# What IsHaunted.com Is

How the site works and who it is for.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

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IsHaunted.com connects people who have experienced something unexplained at a property with paranormal investigation groups who can look into it.

## The short version

A **client** describes what has been happening and asks one or more **groups** to take a look. A group that accepts opens a **case**. From there, the client and the investigators share a timeline of what happened and what was found, and the group schedules **investigations** — visits to the property.

Nothing about a case is public unless the group publishes it, and even then the client's name is replaced by whatever name they chose.

## Who does what

| YOU ARE                        | YOU CAN                                                           |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A visitor                      | Browse groups and any cases that have been published.             |
| A client                       | Ask groups to investigate, log what happens, and follow the case. |
| A group member                 | Work cases, record findings, attend investigations.               |
| A group owner or administrator | Configure the group, manage members, accept or decline requests.  |

## Voting on a published case

Anyone with an account can vote on a published case, and on individual pieces of evidence within it. There are three answers: **confirms**, **inconclusive**, and **disputes**. You get one vote, and changing your mind replaces it rather than adding a second.

Alongside the three counts you will see a single **score**. It is the votes added up, with confirms counting **+1**, disputes **-1**, and inconclusive **0** — so a green **+4** means the people who looked lean towards something being there, and a red **-3** means they lean the other way.

An inconclusive vote is not a wasted one. It counts towards how many people looked while moving the score nowhere, which is exactly what "I've seen it and I genuinely can't say" should do.

The score is always shown with the number of votes behind it, because **+4** from five people and **+4** from ninety are not the same claim. A score of **0** can mean the case is evenly split or that everyone was undecided — the counts beside it tell you which.

## Getting an account

You need an account to request an investigation or join a group. Accounts are free, and the address you sign in with is never shown publicly.

## Finding help

Every page that does something non-obvious has a small ? beside it. That opens the relevant part of this documentation in a new tab, so you never lose what you were in the middle of.

## Getting in touch

**Contact**, in the footer, reaches the people who run the site — not a group. Use it for anything about the site itself: an account you cannot get into, something that looks broken, a question this documentation does not answer. To ask a group to investigate something, send a request instead; that is a different thing entirely and goes to the group, not to us.

You do not need an account to write in. After you send the form you are given a **tracking link** — keep it. It is how you read the reply and see whether the message has been picked up, and it is the only way back to a message sent without an account. If you were signed in when you wrote, the message is attached to your account as well.

# Requesting an Investigation

How to ask a group to look into what you have experienced.

Written for: **Public** — no account needed

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## Before you start

You will be asked to describe what has happened. Write it as plainly as you can, in the order it happened. Investigators find dates, times and who was present far more useful than adjectives — "three knocks on the north wall, about 2am, twice last week" is worth more than "terrifying activity".

## Choosing a group

Use **Find a Group** to see groups working in your area. You can send the same request to more than one; each decides independently whether to take it on.

## What happens next

1. The group reviews your request. They may mark it as under review while they discuss it.
2. If they accept, a **case** is opened and you get access to it under **My Cases**.
3. If they decline, you are told, and you can send the request to a different group without writing it again.

## Your address

Groups need your address to reach you — that is the point of the request. It is never shown on public pages, and it is not shared with groups you did not ask.

# Following Your Case

The case page, logging occurrences, and who can see what.

Written for: Signed-in users

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## The case page

**My Cases** lists every case you are part of, whether you opened it or were invited onto it by someone else. Opening one shows the calendar, everything logged so far, files, and your message thread with the investigators.

## Logging an occurrence

Use **Log Occurrence** whenever something happens. Record it while it is fresh — the date and time matter more than polish. You can attach photos, audio, or video, and you can tag what kind of experience it was so investigators can group similar reports.

Several people can report the same moment. That is expected, not a problem: the timeline shows entries that share a time together and labels them, because two independent accounts of one event are more useful than one.

## Who sees what

| MARKED          | SEEN BY                                |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------|
| Internal        | The investigators only.                |
| Shared with you | The investigators and you.             |
| Public          | Anyone, if the case is ever published. |

Your own reports are always visible to you and to the group working your case.

## How you are named publicly

If a case is ever published, you choose the name shown — "A local family", "The homeowner", or anything you prefer. Set it on your case page under **How You're Named Publicly**.

Your investigators always see your real name. They cannot work a case while blind to who reported it, so the alias applies to public pages and shared documents only.

# Working a Case

The case page from the investigator's side — timeline, files, investigations.

Written for: Group members

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## The case tabs

**Overview** carries the original request exactly as the client submitted it, shown separately from the case description so the two never blur together as the case is edited.

**Timeline** is the working record. Every entry has a visibility: internal to the group, shared with the client, or public. Choose deliberately — "internal" means not shared onward, not hidden from its author.

**Investigations** covers scheduled visits, attendees and RSVPs, and each visit's binder.

## Binders

A binder is the case timeline filtered to one investigation. Entries recorded during a visit stay on the main case timeline as well — that is the point of reusing it rather than keeping a separate store. Filter the timeline by investigation to see just that visit.

## Instrument readings

Readings recorded during a visit go in as **Instrument Reading** entries. Record the value, its unit, and what the ambient baseline was — a reading without its baseline cannot be judged later.

## Entries at the same time

Two people often record the same moment, and unrelated things sometimes coincide. Entries sharing an event time are shown together and labelled "1 of 2 at this time". The ordering is stable, so you can refer to an entry by position and have it still be there tomorrow.

## The investigations map

The group's **Investigations** tab shows every visit the group has run, on one map and in two lists: what is coming up, and what has already happened. Case-bound visits and ones with no client case sit together, because they are the same kind of work.

Visits at the same spot share a single marker with a count on it — the same place accumulating visits over the years is the normal case, not an oddity.

**If something is missing from the map**, look just beneath it. An investigation whose location could not be found on the map is listed there with the reason, rather than quietly leaving the map one pin short. Usually

the address has a typo, and correcting it puts the pin back.

The **Edit** button appears only on visits you are allowed to change. That is decided per investigation rather than by rank: the person who scheduled it, the case manager, whoever is leading that particular visit, group owners and administrators, and anyone the group has specifically granted the investigations permission.

## Scheduling a visit with no case

**Schedule an investigation** on the group's Investigations tab books a visit that belongs to no client case — a landmark, a public building, or the group's own outing. Everything else about it works the same way: it appears on the map, the team can check in, and the findings are shared under the same rules.

Describe where it is, and the form will tell you if the system already knows the place:

*This place may already be on file.*

**Use this place** attaches the visit to the existing record, which is what puts your visit on the same page as everyone else's work at that location. If it is genuinely somewhere new — a different flat in the same building, a different cabin on the same site — carry on typing and a new place is created. The suggestion is only ever offered; nothing is merged behind your back.

A place is only suggested when the address matches **and** it is within about a tenth of a mile. Both have to agree, because an address alone cannot tell two flats apart and a map position alone would suggest the house next door.

## Arriving on site

The investigation's **Team** panel shows who is expected and who has turned up. Open it from the attendees on a case's Investigations tab, or from **Team** on any row of the group's Investigations list — including visits with no case, which is the only way to check in to one of those. A name turns green once their attendance is recorded, and the time beside it is when they say they got there.

Press **I've arrived** to check yourself in. The time is editable, and it is meant to be: most sites have no signal, so checking in the next morning and correcting the time to when you actually got there is the normal way to use it, not a workaround. Times in the future are refused — that is a typo rather than a memory.

Whoever manages the investigation can also record attendance for somebody who forgot. Those two are kept distinct: the panel marks a row **Recorded** when somebody else entered it, so "checked in on site" and "ticked off afterwards" never look like the same thing.

Attendance is what puts a visit on your own map under **My Investigations**.

## Writing up what you saw

Everyone who was on the team files their own account, in the **What people saw** section of the investigation's Team panel. One each, in their own words.



They are deliberately separate accounts rather than one shared write-up. Four people in a building at night see four different nights, and the places where two accounts disagree are usually the most useful part of the record — a single summary, written by whoever holds the edit right, loses them.

**Only you can write yours, and only you can withdraw it.** There is no override, unlike arrival, where somebody else can record that you turned up. Whether you were there is something another person can vouch for; what you experienced is not, and an account with your name on it that you did not write would be worse than no account at all.

You can revise it afterwards — most people write up the next morning and correct it for days after. A revised account is marked as revised, so somebody comparing accounts knows whether they are reading what you said on the night or what you say now.

Everyone in the group can read all the accounts. That is the point of keeping them.

## Tagging what kind of experience it was

Timeline entries can be tagged with experience types — knocking, cold spots, shadow figures — grouped under categories. Tagging is what makes patterns findable later, across cases and across groups, so it is worth a moment even when the write-up already says it.

If nothing in the list fits, group owners and administrators can **add a type inline**. It is usable immediately; nobody has to wait for approval to record tonight. Site administrators are told, and they confirm it or remove it afterwards.

Two things happen quietly to keep that list from filling up with near-misses:

- **We ask before creating a type spelled very like an existing one.** Pick the existing type if that is what you meant, or say yours is different and we add it as typed. It is a question, not a refusal.
- **A type you added disappears again if you untag the last entry using it**, as long as no site administrator has confirmed it yet. A word invented for one occurrence and then removed does not outlive it. Confirmed types stay, and so do the ones we ship.

## Leading a visit

The **Lead** column on the team list marks who is running this particular investigation. It is not a promotion: it applies to this visit only, and it lapses with it.

The lead can edit the investigation — the schedule, the team, the details — for as long as they hold it, and can hand it to somebody else. Only people who can already change the investigation can name a lead, so it cannot be taken, only given.

## Who can see the findings

Each investigation carries its own sharing setting, on the investigation's edit form.

| SETTING                                      | WHO READS IT                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Just this group                              | Only your own group. The default for anywhere somebody lives. |
| Groups who have also investigated this place | Any group with a visit recorded at the same place.            |
| Anyone                                       | Everybody, including visitors who are not signed in.          |

The middle one is worth reading twice: the audience is **whoever has investigated the place**, and that list keeps growing. A group that goes there next year will be able to read what you shared this year. The form says so when you pick it.

You do not have to share your own findings to read what others have shared. The point of the setting is that people comparing notes on the same building is useful, and requiring a contribution first would mostly deter the cautious.

Investigations at a **private residence cannot be made public**. Publishing what happened inside somebody's home is theirs to agree to, and there is no way to ask them yet, so the option is withheld rather than offered without the consent behind it.

## Place pages

Clicking the location on the Investigations tab opens that **place** — every visit recorded there, by every group, that you are allowed to see.

The line at the top counts only what is visible to you. It never says how much is being withheld, because that would be its own way of telling you what you cannot see.

Your own group's visits are listed separately from what other groups have shared, and only your own rows show their sharing setting: how another group chose to share something is their business.

Place pages work for visitors too. Somebody who is not signed in sees only investigations that have been published, and nothing else.

# Your Profile and Photos

Display name, contact details, public and private photos, and who can see them.

Written for: Signed-in users

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## Your profile

**My Profile**, in the menu under your avatar, is where you set your display name and photos. Your sign-in address is not changed here and is never shown publicly.

## Two photos

You can set two pictures, and they are treated very differently.

- **Public photo** — anyone can see it, including visitors to published case pages.
- **Private photo** — shown only to people you actually work with.

## Who sees your private photo

| THEY ARE                                     | THEY SEE IT                                           |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| You                                          | Always.                                               |
| Someone in a group with you                  | Yes — colleagues see each other properly.             |
| A client of a case you are working           | Only if your group allows it <b>and</b> you opted in. |
| Someone on the same case as you, as a client | Yes.                                                  |
| Anyone else                                  | No — they see your public photo, or your initials.    |

The client rule needs both keys. Your group has to allow member photos to be shown to clients, **and** you have to switch it on for yourself. Either one alone shares nothing, and the profile page tells you when you have opted in but no group allows it yet.

## Your contact information

Below the photos you can record as many email addresses, phone numbers, postal addresses and web links as you like. Each one is yours alone — nobody else can add to or edit your list, and an administrator changing their own copy of your record never touches these.

Mark one email and one phone as **Primary** if you want a single obvious "reach me here". Marking a new one primary clears the old one automatically: it is a slot, not a checkbox you can tick twice.

Addresses are looked up on a map as you type. If the lookup finds the place, the coordinates are stored with the address; if it does not, the address still saves — it simply has no pin.

## What public means

Everything you add starts **private**. Private means only you and the people who administer the system can see it; it is never shown on a case page, in a group directory, or to anyone you work with.

Ticking **Public** on one entry publishes that entry, and nothing else. A public email address is the one thing that lets somebody invite you to a calendar event by typing your address — that lookup deliberately ignores your sign-in address, so an unpublished account cannot be found by guessing.

## Confirming an email address

An email address cannot be made public until you have confirmed it. That stops anyone typing a stranger's address into their own profile and then receiving that stranger's invitations.

Press **Send confirmation link** next to the address. If the system is set up to send mail, the link arrives in that inbox. If it is not — which is normal on a test system — the page shows you the link instead so you can copy it.

Opening the link shows the address, partly hidden, and a **Confirm** button. You do not have to be signed in, and you can open it on any device. The address is only confirmed when you press the button, so a mail scanner that follows links cannot confirm it for you.

Links last seven days, and you can only ask for a new one once a minute. Asking for a new link retires the old one. If you later change the address text, the confirmation is cleared and the entry goes back to private — the new address has not been proven, only the old one had.

## Your investigation map

**My Investigations** keeps a map of where you have actually been, under *Where I've been*.

It shows visits you **attended** — not ones you were invited to, and not ones you said yes to. A map of places you might have gone is not a record of where you have been, and only the second is worth keeping.

That means it fills up slowly, and starts empty. Attendance is recorded after the visit, so a scheduled investigation appears in your list straight away but on the map only once someone has confirmed you were there.

# Your Equipment

Logging the gear you own, adding photos, and what stays private.

Written for: Signed-in users

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## Your equipment list

**My Equipment**, in the main menu, is where you record the gear you own — recorders, cameras, meters, lights, anything you take on an investigation. Each piece gets a make and model from the shared catalog, a name you choose, and optionally a serial number, an acquisition date, notes and photos.

Everything starts private to you. Listing a piece publicly, sharing it with a group, and offering it for loan are all separate choices you make piece by piece.

Clicking a piece's name — anywhere it appears — opens its own page. That page shows each reader only what they are entitled to: you see its serial number and condition there, a member of a group you shared it with sees that it is yours and how to ask for it, and a passer-by from the public catalog sees the piece with no mention of you at all.

## What stays private

Two things about a piece of equipment are **never** shown to anyone but you:

- **Who owns it, outside your groups.** The public catalog never links your name to a piece — one you chose to list appears without an owner. Inside a group you have shared with, your name does appear beside your gear: that is the point of sharing, so members know whose kit is whose.
- **The serial number.** This one stays private even later on, when you can share gear with a group and lend it out. Somebody borrowing your recorder does not need its serial number, and neither does the person approving the loan.

Site administrators can see equipment records, as they can everywhere else in the application.

## Adding a piece of equipment

Choose a category first — that narrows the makes and models to sensible ones. Then pick the make, then the model, then give it a name you will recognise in a list, like "my backup recorder".

## When you don't know the make or model

Not everything has a manufacturer and a product name, and you should never have to invent one.

- **No brand at all** — a homemade trigger device, an unbranded flashlight: choose the make **Generic / Unbranded**. Every category has a generic model waiting under it.

- **A known brand with no particular model** — an Eveready flashlight, say: choose the make normally, then use **I don't know the exact model**. That adds a single shared "generic" entry under that make, so everyone in the same position picks the same one instead of typing a dozen different guesses.

## When we ask "did you mean...?"

If you add a make spelled very like one already in the catalog — **Sansung** when **Samsung** is there — we stop and ask before creating it. The catalog is shared by everybody, and one mistyped manufacturer sitting beside the real one looks exactly as genuine as the real one to whoever comes next.

You always have both answers:

- **Pick the suggested make** if that is what you meant, and it is chosen for you.
- **Say yours is different**, and we add it exactly as you typed it. Plenty of real makes are one letter apart — Ring and Ping are two different companies — so this is a question, never a refusal.

We only ask about makes an administrator has already confirmed, so you are never being pointed at somebody else's typo.

## Linking to a make or model

Every make and model has a readable address — `/equipment/zoom/h1n` — so a link you paste into a message says what it points at. If you arrive by an older link, the address bar updates itself to the readable one.

Correcting a name corrects its address too, so a make fixed from "Sansung" to "Samsung" no longer answers to the mistake. That means a catalog link shared before a correction may stop working; the catalog is shared vocabulary, and keeping the typo alive in the URL would be the worse trade.

## Tidying up after yourself

A make or model you added is removed automatically when the last piece of equipment using it goes away, as long as no administrator has confirmed it yet. Type a make wrongly, delete the item, and the mistake leaves with it — you do not need to ask anyone to clear it up.

Confirmed makes and models stay, whether or not anyone currently owns one. Those describe what exists in the world, not just what happens to be in the database this week.

## Who can see a piece, and who can borrow it

These are two separate choices, set per piece of equipment, and both start switched off. Letting people know you own something is not the same as offering to lend it.

**Who can see it.** By default only you. Two ways to widen that, and they are independent:

- **Share it with a group** — use the **Share** button on the piece and tick the groups that should see it. They see the make, model, photos and what you call it, alongside your name. They never see the serial number.

- **List it in the public catalog** — shows the piece under *Gear people own*, visible to anyone, signed in or not. Even then it never carries your name or its serial number.

## Sharing with your groups

Sharing is per piece and per group, so you can put most of your kit in front of a group and keep one piece out of it. You can only share with groups you are actually a member of.

If you have a lot of gear, the **All my gear** row at the top of My Equipment shares or unshares everything with one group at once. It still writes the same per-piece choices underneath, so you can immediately go and untick the one piece you would rather keep back.

A share lasts as long as your membership. If you leave a group, your gear stops appearing to it straight away — the choice is remembered, so it applies again if you rejoin.

**Who can borrow it.** Three options, and you can pick any combination:

| OPTION                     | WHO CAN ASK                                                                | RECORDED AS                                                      |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Groups I've shared it with | A group you've shared the piece with can borrow it for the group's own use | Borrowed for that group, and optionally tied to an investigation |
| People in my groups        | Someone you share a group with, borrowing as themselves                    | A personal loan                                                  |
| Anyone with an account     | Any signed-in user                                                         | A personal loan                                                  |

Leave all three unticked and the piece is never borrowable, however many people can see it. You approve or deny every request either way, and you set how long the loan runs — or leave the due date empty if you are not worried about getting it back by a particular day.

If you allow anyone to borrow a piece but do not list it publicly, the form will say so: people outside your groups have no way to find it, so the offer does nothing until you list it.

## Retiring a piece

When you stop using something, **retire** it rather than deleting it. Retired gear disappears from borrowing and from the public catalog, but its loans and service history stay readable — and you can put it back in service whenever you like.

Once a piece has been lent or serviced, deleting becomes unavailable for exactly that reason: removing it would take the record of what happened to it, including loans other people were part of, along with it.

## What we keep about your photos

A photo carries more than the picture: most phones record where and when it was taken, and which device took it. When you upload one, that information is separated out and stored against the record, and the copy anybody sees has none of it — so a photo of gear at your home does not carry your address with it.

Your original file is kept exactly as you sent it and never shown to anyone. The separated details are readable only by group Administrators and site administrators.

## The public catalog

The **Equipment Catalog** is public — anyone can browse it, including visitors who are not signed in. It has two halves. *Makes & models* is reference data: what gear exists, by make and model. *Gear people own* lists individual pieces whose owners chose to list them. Neither half ever carries who owns anything or any serial number.

When you add a make or model that isn't listed yet, it goes into the catalog as a proposal. You can use it straight away on your own equipment. It appears in the public catalog once a site administrator approves it, which keeps the shared list from filling up with typos and duplicates.

## Make and model pages

Every make and model has its own page, reached by clicking the make and model under any piece of gear. It gathers what everyone who owns one has contributed: how many are owned, how many are offered for borrowing, the manufacturer links people have added, and their photos.

Everything on that page is anonymous. It never says whose photo is whose, or who owns how many. Where you see a photo you can click, that is because you are allowed to open that particular piece — its owner listed it publicly, shared it with a group you are in, or it is your own. Everyone else sees the same photo with no link behind it.

## The manufacturer's page

Each piece of equipment can carry a link to the maker's own page for it. It is optional, and the links everyone adds for the same make and model are gathered on that model's page — so one person's research into a recorder's specifications saves the next person the search.

## Photos

Each item can have as many photos as you like. The first one you add becomes the main photo — the one shown first — and you can promote any other photo to main, or remove any of them.

Photos load when you open your equipment list, not as thumbnails in a long grid, so a list of many items stays quick.

**Hide from the model page** is set on each photo separately. A photo of the piece against a plain wall may be exactly what belongs on a make and model page, while the one taken in your living room is not — so the choice is per photo rather than all-or-nothing. Hiding a photo keeps it on the item itself; it only stops it appearing in the pooled set. Captions you write are shown publicly with the photo, so write them as something a stranger will read.



## Questions and FAQs

Two related things, one public and one private.

**Things worth knowing** is the FAQ you write about your own piece — anything a borrower would want to know before asking for it. It appears on the item's page, and entries from publicly-listed items are also gathered on that make and model's page alongside other owners'. FAQ entries never say who wrote them, anywhere, including on your own item's page.

**Questions** are asked by someone thinking about borrowing. They arrive in **Gear Questions** in the main menu, where you can answer, or decline without answering, and afterwards publish a good answer into the FAQ.

### The anonymity, exactly

A question is anonymous in **both** directions. You will not see who asked. They will not see who answered. The notice announcing a question says only that one arrived.

This is deliberate: a question is how someone finds out whether a thing has a quirk they need to know about, and people do not ask that of a person whose answer might decide whether they get lent the gear at all.

The anonymity covers questions and FAQs only. **Borrowing is not anonymous** — if that same person goes on to ask for the piece, you will each see who the other is, because you should know who is holding your recorder. A group's shared-gear list still names owners too.

Publishing an answer to the FAQ **copies** the text rather than exposing the conversation. You can rewrite it first — what reads well as a reply to one person rarely reads well as a public answer — and the original thread is left as it was said. An answer can be published once.

## Feedback and moderation

After a loan comes back, both sides can leave feedback about the other. Neither ever sees what was written about them — not on any page, and there is no notification, because telling someone feedback about them exists is most of the way to showing it to them. What lenders write is shown to future lenders deciding that person's next request; what borrowers write is shown, unattributed, to other borrowers considering asking. The full rules are in [Borrowing Equipment](#).

A group's **Administrators and Owner** can open **Equipment feedback** from the group's page. It lists everything left about the group's gear and its members' loans, naming both sides, and anything that crosses a line can be removed. That page exists so a complaint can be acted on — it is the one place in the app where feedback is attributed on both ends.

## Who is looking

Each piece counts how many times its page has been opened and how many times someone followed its manufacturer link. Those numbers are shown to the Administrators and Owner of the group that owns the

equipment, and to site administrators. Nobody else sees them — not other members, and not the individual owner of a personal piece.

The counts are totals only. Nothing is recorded about who did the looking.

# Borrowing Equipment

Asking to borrow gear, handing it over, and getting it back.

Written for: Signed-in users

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Equipment can be borrowed from two places: gear a group owns, and gear a member owns personally and has offered to lend. The steps are the same either way. What differs is who decides.

## Who decides

| WHOSE GEAR      | WHO APPROVES                                                  |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| The group's own | Anyone with the group's <b>Equipment Checkouts</b> permission |
| A member's own  | That member, always                                           |

Nobody's group permission lets them lend out somebody else's personal equipment. If it is yours, the decision is yours.

## Asking to borrow

Find the piece and choose **Ask to borrow**. Gear turns up in two places: your group's **Equipment** tab, and the public **Equipment Catalog** under *Gear people own*.

If the owner lends the piece to more than one group you are in, you will be asked **who you are borrowing it for**. That choice matters: a loan taken out for a group is recorded against that group, and can be tied to a particular visit. A loan you take out personally is just yours.

If the owner only lends the piece personally, there is nothing to choose and no group is recorded.

You can add when you need it and a note about why. Neither is required, but a note is the difference between a request somebody can say yes to and one they have to ask about first.

You can only have one open request per piece at a time. Asking twice is a duplicate, not a nudge.

## Asking a question first

Every piece has its own page, reached by clicking its name. On it you will find **Things worth knowing** — an FAQ the owner has written — and an **Ask a question** button if there is something they have not covered.

Questions are **anonymous in both directions**. Whoever looks after the piece sees your question but not your name, and their answer comes back without theirs. Ask whatever you actually need to know: this exists precisely so that finding out about a temperamental battery door does not cost you the loan.

Anonymity stops at the question. If you go on to **ask to borrow**, that request carries your name, as it must — you are asking someone to hand you their equipment.

Your questions and their answers are in **Gear Questions** in the main menu.

## Being turned down

Whoever declines has to give a reason, and you will see it. A bare "no" tells you nothing about whether to ask again next week.

A declined request is final — the row stays as a record of what was asked. If circumstances change, send a fresh request.

## Handing over and getting back

Each side confirms the transfer coming toward them.

- **You confirm you have it.** Once your request is approved, the loan is not "out" until you press **I've got it**. The person with the equipment is the one who can truthfully say they have it.
- **The lender confirms it came back.** When you return it, they press **Got it back**, optionally noting the condition. This is deliberately not yours to do: a loan should not be closable by asserting you returned something.

Until you confirm the hand-off you can still **cancel** — plans change, and an approved request you never collected should not have to become a loan.

## Due dates and overdue

Whoever approves can set a date it is due back, or leave it open if they are not worried.

A loan is **overdue** once it is out and past that date. That is worked out fresh every time anyone looks, so it is never stale, and it shows as a red badge on **My Checkouts** and a count on your notification bell.

## Photos of its condition

Either side can attach photos to a loan — as the gear goes out, and as it comes back. They sit side by side on the loan's **Details** view, which is the whole point: "was that scratch already there?" is much easier to answer with the two pictures next to each other than from memory.

A hand-off photo can only be added once the loan is approved and before it is over, and a return photo only once the gear is actually out or just back. Photographing a hand-off that never happened would be recording a fact about nothing.

Condition photos are private to the two sides of that loan. They never appear in the public catalog.

## Asking for more time

If you need a piece for longer, open the loan's **Details** and ask to keep it until a later date. You can only ask while you actually have the gear, and only one request can be waiting at a time.

Whoever lent it can grant or refuse. Granting moves the due date; refusing leaves the original date standing and needs a reason. Either way you get a notification, and the request and its answer stay on the loan — so "asked for another week, was given three days" is still readable later, rather than just a due date that quietly changed.

## Feedback after a loan

Once a piece is back, both sides can leave feedback on the loan's page. It is optional, and you can leave a comment, a rating out of five, or both.

**Neither side ever sees what was written about them.** There is no notification either, because telling someone that feedback about them exists is most of the way to showing it to them. What each half is for:

- **What a lender writes about a borrower** is shown to *future lenders* weighing that person's next request — so somebody deciding whether to hand over an expensive recorder can see that the last few lenders got it back on time and in one piece. It carries the lender's name, because an unattributed warning is hard to weigh.
- **What a borrower writes about a lender** is shown to *other borrowers* thinking of asking them, **without your name**. The protection goes where there is more to lose.

Borrowers can also review **the equipment itself**, separately. That one is public: it appears on the make and model's catalog page, still without your name, and helps somebody deciding whether the thing is worth buying or borrowing at all.

Averages are never shown from fewer than three ratings, and always appear with their count beside them — one sour rating is one voice, not a verdict.

A group's Administrators and Owner can see everything left about their group's gear and loans, and remove anything that crosses a line.

## My Checkouts

**My Checkouts** answers three questions in one place:

- **Borrowing** — what you have out, and what you have asked for
- **Waiting on me** — requests for your gear needing a decision, and your gear currently out with somebody

Groups with the **Equipment Checkouts** permission also get a queue of every loan of the group's gear, on the group's own Equipment tab.

# Administering a Group

Settings, members, requests, and the decisions only owners and administrators make.

Written for: Group owners & administrators

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Visible to owners and administrators of a group. Managers and members work cases but do not configure the group itself.

## Group settings

The group's **Edit** screen holds its public identity — name, URL, contact details — and two switches worth understanding.

**Accepting membership applications** controls whether people can apply to join.

### Your web address

Your group lives at `/o/your-address` — the link you put on a card, in a post, or in an email to a client. It can use lowercase letters, numbers and hyphens, like `ghost-squad`. Spaces, slashes and punctuation are refused, and a handful of words the site uses itself are reserved.

No two groups can share an address, and **you can change yours whenever you like**. When you do:

- **The old address keeps working.** Every link anyone has already shared still opens your pages — visitors are simply moved along to the new address, so what they copy next is the current one.
- **The old address stays yours.** No other group can take it later, even years on. Pointing somebody's saved link at a different group would be worse than the link not working at all.

So changing your address is safe. Changing it often is still worth avoiding, because the address is what people remember.

**Let clients see members' private photos** is one half of a two-key rule. Turning it on shares nothing by itself; it only permits members who have *also* opted in on their own profile. This is deliberate: a group cannot volunteer its members' faces, and a member cannot overrule a group that has decided its people stay unidentified to clients.

## Members and roles

| ROLE          | TYPICALLY                                 |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Owner         | Created the group. Full control.          |
| Administrator | Configures the group and manages members. |
| Manager       | Runs cases day to day.                    |
| Member        | Works cases and attends investigations.   |
| Viewer        | Reads without changing anything.          |

## The Investigations tab

Every visit the group has run, mapped and listed, including ones that belong to no client case. It is visible to every member, not only administrators — knowing where the group has worked is ordinary team knowledge, not an administrative secret.

**Schedule an investigation** books a visit with no case behind it. What the group finds there is shared under the same rules as any other investigation.

## Who can change an investigation

Being a member is enough to *read* an investigation and to answer for yourself — your own RSVP and your own arrival. Changing the record itself is narrower. Any one of these is enough:

- whoever scheduled it
- the case manager, for a visit attached to a case
- whoever is leading that particular visit
- group owners and administrators
- anyone the group has granted the **Investigation** permission under **Roles**

That last one is the lever you have as an administrator. Grant a role the *Update* action on **Investigation**, give somebody that role, and they can edit any of the group's investigations without being made an administrator of everything else.

**Leading a visit is not a rank.** It is set per investigation, in the **Lead** column of the investigation's team list, and it ends with that visit. One person leads at a time — naming a lead takes it from whoever held it — and the current lead can hand it on, which is what happens when somebody leaves halfway through the night. Somebody senior enough to lead every visit is better served by the permission above; somebody leading one Saturday is better served by the lead flag, which stops mattering on Sunday.

## Incoming requests

Client requests arrive under the group's **Requests**. Mark one as under review while you decide. Declining tells the client, and lets them send it elsewhere without rewriting it.

## The group calendar

The group's **Calendar** holds meetings, training, anything with a time attached. Investigations are scheduled from the case they belong to, not here.

**Where it happens.** Type a free-text location, or pick one of the group's saved addresses. Prefer the saved address: it is stored as a reference rather than copied text, so correcting the address once corrects every event held there. A **meeting link** can sit alongside it — paste a Zoom, Teams or Meet join link, and a bare `zoom.us/j/123` is accepted as readily as the full URL.

**Repeating events.** The **Repeats** list covers the usual patterns — daily, weekly, monthly, and so on. **Custom** takes an iCal rule directly ( `FREQ=WEEKLY;BYDAY=TU` ) for a pattern the list does not cover.

**Invites.** A public event is open to the whole group by definition, so invites appear only on a non-public one. Tick members from the list, or type an email address to invite somebody outside the group. That lookup only finds addresses their owner has published *and confirmed* on their own profile — never the private address someone signs in with. If an address does not resolve, the person either has no account or has not published that address; ask them rather than guessing at another spelling.

Invites are invitations, nothing more. Assigning work belongs to investigations, where it already exists.

## Calendar event types

Under **Settings**, *Calendar Event Types* is the list the calendar's **Type** dropdown offers — Investigation, Meeting, Training, whatever the group actually does. A group with no types can still create events; the events simply have no type.

Each type carries a name, an optional colour and icon, and a sort order that decides where it sits in the dropdown. Only owners and administrators can change the list.

Clear **Active** to retire a type. It disappears from the dropdown for new events but stays on the events that already use it — which is almost always what you want. Deleting one removes it from those events too, leaving their date and title untouched.

## The Equipment tab

Two lists, because a group deals with two kinds of gear.

**The group's gear** is equipment the group itself owns. Every member can see the list — what the group has is not a secret from the people who use it — but adding, editing and deleting it needs the **Equipment** permission, and so does seeing serial numbers.

Each piece tracks who is holding it, when it was last serviced, whether it is currently faulty, and its photos. **Held by** can be set by hand: kit gets passed over in a car park without anyone opening the app, and the



record should still be able to tell the truth. A holder has to be an active member.

**History** on a piece opens two things: the full account of everything that has happened to it — loans, requests for more time, service and faults, newest first — and the service log itself, where new entries are added.

The service log part is what you write to. Anyone can read it; adding an entry needs the Equipment permission. The entry type does real work rather than just labelling the note:

| ENTRY          | WHAT IT DOES TO THE ITEM                                |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Serviced       | Moves its last-serviced date                            |
| Fault reported | Marks the piece faulty, and the note becomes the reason |
| Fault fixed    | Clears the fault                                        |

The entry and its consequence are saved together, so the log never disagrees with the piece it describes. Entries are kept — fixing a fault does not erase the report of it.

Once a piece has any loan or service history, deleting it is refused and you are asked to **retire** it instead — the button sits in the item editor. Retired gear drops out of borrowing, out of the public catalog and out of the group list, while everything that happened to it stays readable. You can put it back in service the same way. Destroying a serial-numbered asset would take the account of what happened to it along too.

**Members' shared gear** is the second list: equipment members own personally and have chosen to show this group. It is read-only here — it belongs to its owner — and it needs no permission to read, because the sharing itself is the owner's decision, not the group's to gate. Serial numbers stay with owners even here.

The **Borrowing** column says whether a piece can be borrowed at all, which is a separate choice from sharing it — a member can let the group know they own something without offering to lend it. Whether a particular piece is offered to the group or only lent personally is shown when you actually ask to borrow it, since that is the point at which the difference matters.

A shared piece disappears from this tab if its owner leaves the group. Their sharing choice is kept, so it comes back if they rejoin.

## The two equipment permissions

Under **Roles**, equipment has two entries, and the second sits underneath the first because it is narrower:

- **Equipment** — manage what the group owns: add and edit gear, upload its photos, keep its service log, set who is holding a piece, and see serial numbers. Read access to the list needs nothing at all beyond membership.
- **Equipment Checkouts** — run the loans desk: approve and deny borrowing requests, hand gear over and receive it back. This is the "Equipment Management" job in item #55's own words.

They are separate so a group can hand someone the loans desk without also handing them the catalog. Deciding what the group buys and owns, and lending out what it already has, are different jobs and often different people. Granting **Equipment** does not grant **Equipment Checkouts**.

Neither permission has any say over a member's personal gear. A loan of somebody's own equipment is always approved by its owner.

## Editing your public pages

Pages you build under **CMS** appear on your group's public site. Two things control what visitors see, and they are different.

**Published** decides whether the page exists for visitors at all. **Drafts** decide whether the edits you are making right now are visible while you make them.

### Drafts

Editing a page that is **not** published changes it directly. Nobody can see it, so there is nothing to protect.

Editing a page that **is** published works differently. Open it and you will be offered **Work on a draft instead**. Take it, and your changes go into a copy — the live page carries on exactly as it was until you press **Publish changes**. Until then, visitors see the old version, and you can **Discard draft** to throw the work away and leave the live page untouched.

A page has one draft at a time. If a colleague has already started one, you will see a note saying so with a link to open it, rather than being handed a second copy nobody knows about.

Publishing keeps the page's address and its permissions — the live page is updated in place, not replaced, so nothing linking to it breaks.

### Page addresses

A page's address is the last part of its web address — `/o/your-group/about` . Keep it short and lowercase; it is what people paste to each other.

A few words are used by the site itself — **cases** and **events** today, plus some held back for things coming later. A page can't use one, because it could never be opened: the site would show its own page at that address instead. If you try, you'll be told which word and offered a way round it — "our-cases" rather than "cases".

If you have an older page marked **Unreachable** in the list, that is one made before this check existed. Rename it and it will start working.

### Seeing a page before it goes live

**View as visitor** on the editor opens the saved page exactly as the public renderer draws it, published or not. That is the honest check: the side-by-side panel next to the editor follows what you are typing, but it draws its own approximation in half a column, so a page can look right there and wrong in reality.

The preview also tells you if the page is not in the menu yet, which is the usual reason a freshly-published page seems to have vanished.

## Putting your cases and investigations on a page

Two section types — **Our investigations** and **Our cases** — let you show your own work on a public page. Pick which records to show, and answer two questions about each section.

**Where it happened.** You can show the rough area, or nothing at all. There is no option to publish the exact address, whichever way you set it: the point shown on the map is the centre of an area several miles across and cannot be traced back to a building. That is deliberate — a case is somebody's home, and a link outlives the page it was on.

**Who it was for.** Cases can show the client's chosen name. Only the alias the client picked, or the one your group set for them — a real name is never published here. If neither is set, the case appears with no name.

**Work that is not public yet** is flagged in the picker, and adding it asks you to confirm. Until you do, those records are left off the page entirely. Publishing a private investigation makes it readable by anyone who visits, including the person it is about.

You can only show your own group's work. Everything is looked up fresh each time somebody views the page, so if a client later asks to be unnamed, they disappear from pages you published months ago — you do not have to remember which ones.

## Public events

An event on your calendar can be opened to anybody. Tick **Public** and it appears on your group's public site, on the site-wide **What's on** list, and anyone with an account can say they are coming.

This is the one part of the site that brings you people who have never heard of you. Somebody looking for a ghost walk near them finds your event, turns up, and meets the group — so the listing names you prominently and reads as an invitation rather than a record.

## What can be made public

Events at **landmarks, businesses, and your own addresses**. Not events at a private residence, and not events attached to a case.

That is deliberate and cannot be overridden. A public listing is a date and an address advertised to strangers, and a client did not agree to have people turn up at their home. If you want to publicise work you are doing on a case, create a separate event for a venue that is yours to publish.

## Hiding the address until somebody is coming

**Hide exact location** shows the town but not the street address. Whoever is coming sees the full address once they have said so; nobody else ever receives it, and the listing says as much up front so nobody feels tricked into signing up to find out where they are going.

If somebody cancels, the address stops being shown to them.

## Places and sign-ups

- **Places** caps how many people can come. Leave it empty for no limit.

- **Sign-ups close** sets a cut-off. Leave it empty and people can sign up right up to the start.
- Somebody who cancels frees their place for somebody else.

### **The link you can share**

A public event gets a readable web address — `/o/your-group/events/2026-08-24-ghost-walk` — made from its date and title the first time you publish it. That is the link to put on social media.

It does not change afterwards, even if you rename the event. A link somebody has already shared should keep working.

### **People coming who don't have an account**

Somebody who finds your event and has never been here before doesn't have to sign up for anything first. They give an email address, we send them a link, and clicking it is what actually confirms they're coming.

The link matters: an address typed into a box proves nothing, and an event that hides its exact location until people are coming would be protecting nothing if anyone could type any address and be shown where you're meeting.

Confirming makes them an account with no password. They can set one later if they want to sign in properly, but they don't have to — it exists so you have somebody you can reach, and so they can see what they've said they're going to.

You'll see them in the attendee list like anybody else.

# Site Administration

Sitewide settings, the clipart library, and the audit log.

Written for: Platform administrators

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Visible to app administrators only.

## Site settings

**Administration** → **Site Settings** holds values that apply to the whole site. Nothing personal belongs here — settings about one person live on their profile, settings about one group live in that group's settings.

Adding a new setting is a code change, not a database one: settings are declared in `SiteSettingKeys.Seed`, and the page renders whatever is declared.

## The clipart library

**Administration** → **Clipart Library** curates the shared artwork every group can use in the video editor. Upload the file first, then publish it here by its file id. The format is read from the file itself — SVG, PNG, WebP, AVIF, GIF or Lottie — and anything else is refused rather than published as something the editor cannot draw.

Assets are **retired**, never deleted. Projects reference artwork by id, so removing one would break renders that already use it. A retired asset leaves the catalog and stays downloadable.

## Keeping the shared vocabulary tidy

Two lists grow by proposal rather than by decree: the **experience taxonomy** and the **equipment catalog**. Groups add what they need on the night, and you confirm or clear up afterwards.

**Confirming** an entry marks it as reviewed. That matters beyond the badge: reviewed entries are the only ones offered as "did you mean" suggestions to the next person, and they stop being cleared away automatically. Confirming is how a word becomes shared vocabulary rather than one group's note.

**Renaming** does what it says — until the new name is already taken. Then you are shown the entry it collided with and offered a merge, because renaming onto an existing name means two things become one and somebody's records change meaning. That is too large to happen because a name was typed, so it is always a second, deliberate step.

**Merging** moves everything across and removes the duplicate. It cannot be undone. Two guards:

- You cannot merge a **confirmed** entry into an unconfirmed one. That is almost always the direction reversed, and the result would be a list where the endorsed word vanished and the mistake survived. Merge the other way, or confirm the target first.

- You cannot merge an experience type into a **different category**. Moving a tagging from Visual to Auditory changes what somebody recorded about their own night, which is not a rename.

**Deleting** is only for an entry nothing uses. If it is tagged on something, you are told how many and refused — **Reject** is the action that removes a type together with its taggings, and it tells you how many it took with it.

Most tidying happens without you. An unconfirmed entry that a group proposed disappears on its own once the last thing using it is gone.

## Support tickets

**Administration** → **Support Tickets** is the queue for the public contact form. A ticket arrives as **New**; replying to the sender marks it **Answered** and assigns it to you if nobody had it.

The sender reads the thread through a private tracking link, whether or not they have an account — that is how a reply reaches someone who cannot sign in. **Internal notes are never shown there**. They are for staff talking among themselves, and adding one does not mark the ticket answered.

Contact details shown beside the form — postal address, phone, email, when we reply — are site settings, so they are corrected on the Site Settings page rather than in a deploy.

## Audit log

**Administration** → **Audit Log** records every mutation with who made it. It is filtered and paged on the server, so date and user filters apply to the whole history rather than the page on screen.